ground still provides players with probably the best nets in the country.

Durban is warm in winter and very warm in summer, and Kingsmead is one of the most picturesque grounds in the country. Situated a few hundred metres from the Indian Ocean, the pitch can be a mystery. I have scored several centuries there but, for one reason or another, it has generally felt like hard work.

In the heart of the country, in the middle of the Free State, Bloemfontein is a tidy and well-organised city, and Springbok Park is a tidy, well-organised and excellent cricket ground. I have also enjoyed playing in both Kimberley and Potchefstroom, the kinds of places where the facilities are outstanding, the crowds sympathetic and where no one will be remotely bothered if you prefer to walk around without shoes.

The Wanderers Stadium in Johannesburg ranks among the leading cricket stadiums in the world, and the famous old Bullring is some place when a capacity crowd turns up to watch a day-night international. The grandstands seem to tower over the outfield and there is always a great vibe on the grassed bank in front of the changing rooms. The renovated home changing room is the best changing room in the country – maybe even the world.

These are the stadiums where international cricket is played in South Africa; these are the places where, summer after summer, I go to work and, over the years, I have learned to be well prepared.

Some cricketers are notoriously superstitious, and it's also true that the mothers of cricketers can be notoriously superstitious – I understand that my mother insists that nobody is allowed to move while I am batting. But, for some reason, I have never been superstitious at all. I have a few settled routines, but that's all.

A batsman requires a reasonable amount of equipment, so it's important to be organised.

I usually carry four or five bats in my cricket bag and, before each innings, I will look at them and feel them and make a decision on which